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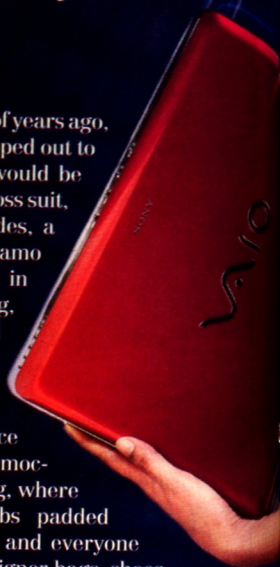
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Spreading affluence, fancier retail outlets, availability of global brands and a new disease called Technolust combine to flood the Great Indian Bazaar with the hottest products available. From the millionaire to the 250-million-strong middle-class, everyone is indulging in retail therapy.

■ By Dilip Bobb

Here's the thing. A couple of years ago, if Mr and Mrs Gupta stepped out to make a statement, he would be decked out in his Hugo Boss suit, a Bvlgari watch, Tag Heuer shades, a Nokia communicator, and Ferragamo shoes. She would be resplendent in Prada, sporting a Louis Vuitton bag, Chanel shades, Dior jewellery and Jimmy Choo stilettos. They would have been in a minuscule minority, confident of their exclusivity. Not so now. The spread of affluence means that Brand bling has been democratised. Go to a Big Indian Wedding, where the upper and middle-class rubs padded shoulders with the seriously rich, and everyone seems to be sporting expensive designer bags, shoes, jewellery, attire and cellphones. It's getting tougher to tell the wealthy from the wannabes.

Affluence and availability are the key. Eight years ago, only one of the brands the Gupta's sported—Louis Vuitton—was available in India. Today, they have all set up shop in India. Jimmy Choo is coming soon to a retail outlet near you as are Dior and Hermes. Others awaiting official FDI clearance include Gucci, Calvin Klein, La Pearl, Tod, D&G and Tumi, the luxury luggage makers. DLF is in talks to bring in Armani, while Arvind will do the same for Polo Ralph Lauren. The impact of India's continuing economic growth is clearly creating a sustainable market for such brands (see *luxury box*). From the millionaire to the 250-million-strong middle-class with money to burn, they are all indulging in retail therapy at the Great Indian



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